

2026-05-28 — Pat POC Question and Answer Session

Context

As part of the NetBackup replacement initiative, we are currently evaluating Cohesity through a Proof of Concept (PoC).

A knowledge-sharing session was held with Pat, who has previous experience implementing enterprise backup platforms including Cohesity and Rubrik, to understand practical lessons learned, common pitfalls, operational considerations, and areas to focus on during the PoC phase.

The discussion also included topics and prompts raised by Ross to help shape our own evaluation approach.

Key Discussion Themes

1. Sizing and Capacity Planning

Key Advice

The strongest recommendation was to size the platform properly from the beginning and ensure substantial headroom for growth.

Important Considerations

- Use **real production-like data** during the PoC wherever possible.
- Validate:
 - Deduplication ratios
 - Compression effectiveness
 - SQL Server workload behaviour
 - M365 growth projections
- Vendors can sometimes provide conservative or optimistic sizing assumptions which may not reflect actual production usage.

Real-World Example

- Environment sized at approximately:
 - **1.2PB raw**
 - Reduced to approximately **600TB effective** after deduplication/compression.
- Pricing was generally based on **usable TB**.

Recommendation

Ensure:

- Future infrastructure growth is included
 - M365 backup growth is factored into storage calculations
 - Sufficient performance overhead exists for production scaling
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2. PoC Objectives

What the PoC Should Prove

The PoC should validate that the platform can meet all core operational and recovery requirements.

Areas to Validate

- SQL Server backup and restore performance
- Granular M365 recovery
- Immutability and ransomware protection
- Reporting and auditing
- Backup integrity validation
- Restore testing automation
- Operational usability
- RBAC and quorum protection
- Cross-platform workload support
- Retention and compliance requirements

Critical Message

Every feature that matters in production must be thoroughly tested during the PoC.

3. Gap Between PoC and Production

A common risk highlighted was that PoCs often:

- use reduced datasets,
- simplified networking,
- or non-production volumes.

This can hide:

- ingress bottlenecks,

- firewall complexity,
- scaling issues,
- and operational overhead.

Additional Considerations

- Locked-down environments can create firewall and networking challenges.
 - Restore testing at scale is essential.
 - Production operational support processes should also be validated, not just the technology itself.
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4. Operational and Security Features

Positive Feedback on Cohesity

User Experience

- Considered a genuine “single pane of glass” solution.
- Reported as intuitive and easy to manage.
- Suitable for both SMEs and BAU operational teams.

Performance

- Backup windows reportedly reduced significantly:
 - Example reduction:
 - ~25 minutes
 - down to ~2 minutes in some workloads.

Security Features

Strong feedback around:

- DataLock immutability
- Built-in ransomware protection
- Threat detection capabilities
- Monitoring for mass file changes
- MFA integration
- Quorum approval processes for destructive actions

Operational Assurance

Recommendation to:

- Automate recovery testing

- Restore regularly into test environments
 - Produce reporting for assurance and audit purposes
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5. M365 Backup Considerations

Native M365 Protection

Capabilities highlighted included:

- Exchange Online backups
- SharePoint backups
- OneDrive backups
- Teams backups
- Granular recovery
- Long-term retention

Benefits

- Reduces dependency on native Microsoft retention capabilities
- Greater control of recoveries and retention policy management
- SaaS-based protection model

Important Caveat

Additional licensing costs may apply for:

- Entra ID / Active Directory forest-level backups

This was specifically called out as an area where unexpected cost increases can occur.

6. Vendor and Commercial Considerations

Key Lessons

Vendor Optimism

It was noted that vendors may:

- oversell features,
- recommend unnecessary add-ons,
- or gloss over licensing nuances.

Examples

Potential additional costs:

- AD Forest backups
- Premium feature licensing
- Expanded retention usage
- Cloud storage growth

Main Observation

Most implementation challenges were viewed as:

- commercial discussions,
 - rather than technical limitations.
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7. Support and Cyber Recovery Experience

Cyber Incident Experience

Pat referenced involvement during a cyber attack response.

Observations

- Significant effort required for:
 - scanning,
 - investigation,
 - and recovery operations.
- Incident response support involved third parties including Blackberry.

Importance

This reinforced the value of:

- immutable backups,
 - threat detection,
 - and tested recovery procedures.
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8. Comparison with Rubrik

General Feedback

Similarities

Cohesity and Rubrik were described as:

- functionally very similar,
- with comparable strategic approaches and feature sets.

Rubrik Deployment Example

- Raytheon reportedly selected Rubrik.
- Decision influenced partly by US organisational bias/preference.

Additional Note

Arnold Clark were mentioned as an early adopter of Cohesity.

9. Key Recommendations

Primary Recommendations from the Session

Technical

- Test every required feature thoroughly during the PoC
- Use realistic production-scale datasets
- Validate restore capabilities, not just backups
- Include M365 in sizing exercises
- Automate recovery validation where possible

Security

- Validate:
 - MFA
 - quorum approval
 - immutability
 - ransomware detection
- Ensure recovery processes are fully documented and tested

Commercial

- Understand all licensing components early
- Clarify:

- storage charging model,
- retention pricing,
- AD/Entra backup licensing,
- cloud-related costs
- Avoid purchasing unnecessary feature packs

Operational

- Validate support responsiveness
 - Confirm firewall/networking requirements early
 - Ensure the solution can be operated by standard support teams, not only SMEs
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Overall Takeaway

The overall sentiment was positive toward Cohesity, particularly around:

- usability,
- ransomware resilience,
- operational simplicity,
- and M365 integration.

The strongest recurring message was:

Ensure the platform genuinely meets all core operational and recovery requirements, and thoroughly validate those requirements during the PoC using realistic workloads and restore testing.